

The Biebrza Marshes

A large Central European wetland area with a wide variety of habitats supporting flourishing populations of birds and mammals

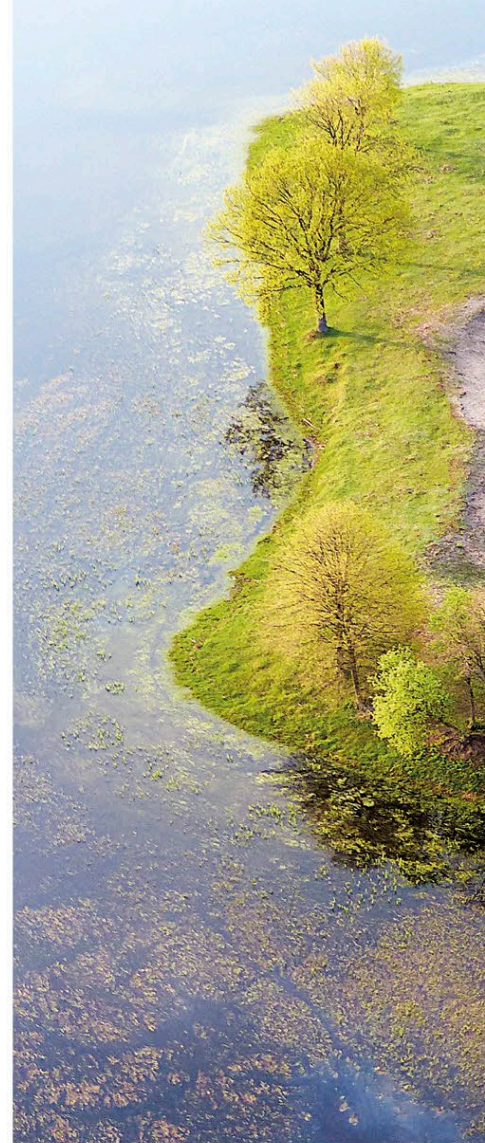
Centered on the Biebrza river valley in the far northeast of Poland, the Biebrza Marshes are a diverse wetland complex covering an area of more than 390 square miles (1,000 square km). The region features a mosaic of habitats including extensive marshes and reedbeds (see panel, right), grasslands, river channels, lakes, low islands, and wooded higher grounds. The area also includes one of the largest and best-preserved peat bogs in Central Europe. In many sections of the Biebrza Marshes, classic examples of ecological succession (see p.60) can be seen, as marshes grade first into raised peat bogs and then gradually into wet woodland.



The varied habitats of the Biebrza Marshes support a wide range of wildlife, and it has been recognized as a site of global significance. The area is one of the most important breeding sites for wetland birds in Central Europe, and more than 270 bird species have been recorded. Mammals include wetland specialists such as moose, beavers, and muskrats, as well as a few packs of wolves.

◀ WATER LOVER

Called moose in North America and elk in Europe, they usually live close to water and are excellent swimmers. Up to half of their diet consists of aquatic plants, although they also graze on trees and shrubs.



The Hortobágy Wetlands

A vast flooded grassland area in the Hungarian steppe region, regarded as one of the world's most important wetland reserves



Located on the upper reaches of the Tisza River in an area known as Puszta on the Great Hungarian Plain, the Hortobágy Wetlands is a steppe—a plain of grasslands and shrubs—that experiences regular flooding. This has turned an otherwise semiarid area into a wetland ecoregion of marshes, streams, and reedbed-lined lakes and lagoons. Part of the largest continuous natural grassland in Europe, the Hortobágy Wetlands is a key section of a national park that covers an area of 310 square miles (800 square km).

One of the best birdwatching sites in Europe, the Hortobágy Wetlands has a year-round wealth of birds. More than 340 bird species have been sighted here, and almost half have nested in the area.

▷ STEALTHY PREDATOR

Common in European wetland areas, the great egret wades through shallow water feeding mainly on fish, frogs, and small mammals, which it spears with its long, sharp bill.

In **fall**, up to **70,000 common cranes rest and feed** at Hortobágy

